The 6:15

THURSDAY · NOVEMBER 5, 2026 NO. 37

THE BOARD

CALENDAR — NEXT 10 DAYS

Thu 11/5 (today)	Weekly jobless claims, 8:30a ET — not out at press time.
Fri 11/6	October jobs report (NFP), 8:30a ET; no consensus verified this run.
Mon 11/9	Veterans Day observed — markets open, bond market closed.
Tue 11/10	October CPI, 8:30a ET.
Fri 11/13	October PPI, 8:30a ET.
Sun 11/29	Next OPEC+ meeting.

No FOMC in this window (Fed holds 3.50%–3.75%; next decision Dec. 9). OPEC+'s Nov. 1 meeting resolved overnight (below, Geopolitics) — yesterday's flag cleared. No frontier AI release, rocket launch, or large VC round cleared verification in the last 24–48h.

METRICS · ~5:10A ET UNLESS NOTED

Brent / WTI	Sources disagree sharply: Brent $93.65–$96.15, WTI $86.98–$88.63 **[flag, wide spread]**; all agree: 4th straight down session
S&P / Nasdaq fut.	S&P 7,722.25 (+0.02%); Nasdaq-100 28,393.50 (−0.61%), 5:07a
VIX	16.88 (+1.62%), ~5:02a — still down hard from Mon.'s 21.27
10Y / 30Y / 5Y	10Y 4.894% (Wed close, −0.058); 30Y 5.28%; 5Y 4.689%; 2Y not independently confirmed **[flag]**
DXY	101.51 (−0.06%), 5:07a — little changed from Wed.'s 101.31
Gold	$4,133.10 (+1.48%), 5:07a — extending Wed.'s rally
Asia (Thu close)	Nikkei 61,077.90 (−1.79%); Hang Seng 24,796.98 (+3.67%); Shanghai 3,689.91 (+0.10%); Kospi 5,383.80 (−5.28%) **[flag, single-sourced]**

Europe	Not independently confirmed this run **[flag, continuity]**
Retail gas (AAA)	$4.1003/gal nat'l avg. (11/5), down from $4.1239 (11/4)

Brent/WTI/equities/VIX/gold: Yahoo Finance, delayed quotes, no settle yet at press time. Rates: Yahoo/CNBC cross-check. Kospi's −5.28% could not be corroborated against a second source this run.

HORMUZ COUNTERS — STRAITS.LIVE, 05 NOV 10:16Z (DAY 249)

Transits	Still 2/day (25 Oct, PortWatch) vs. 85/day baseline — now 11 days stale, unrevised
Dark tankers (24h)	94/212 screened, 44.3% — sharp drop from Wed.'s 69.4% **[DEVELOPING]**
War-risk premium	~32.0x pre-crisis — estimate 29 days stale, unrevised
Indices	Crisis Pressure 88±7 (Extreme, flat); Escalation Forecast 53±10 (Elevated, −5 vs. Wed.'s 58)

Transit count (PortWatch, AIS-confirmed only), dark-tanker screen (AIS-silence proxy) and war-risk premium (insurance estimate) measure different things on different cadences — not additive. The one-day dark-tanker swing may reflect changed signal coverage, not a change in evasive behavior; straits.live's own note says treat the count as a floor on lost AIS, not a measure of smuggling.

TRANSACTIONS

Yankees	Bednar's $23.15M qualifying offer confirmed issued Nov. 2 (AP) — yesterday's flag cleared
Knicks	Beat Chicago 135-105 Wed. night, now 4-4 **[flag, single-sourced]**
Northwestern	No game since Oct. 31 loss at Oregon; next Sat. 11/7 vs. Iowa, home

LEAD

OIL · HORMUZ

Crude's fourth straight drop is pricing a Hormuz de-escalation the strait's own data hasn't confirmed

Oil is now on its fourth consecutive down session, a separate trade from Tuesday's election-driven equity rally and the bigger mover this morning. Brent has fallen from a peak near $118 late last week to readings in the $93–$96 range at press time — sources disagree by close to $3 within the same hour, but all agree on direction and on a roughly 15%–20% slide in under a week. WTI shows the same pattern, quoted anywhere from $86.98 to $88.63 depending on the feed. The proximate drivers, per wire reporting: Trump saying the US has no immediate plans to strike Iran, intensified Qatari mediation, and a market narrative that Hormuz shipping has "recovered close to pre-war levels." That last claim is the one this brief cannot support from its own counters.

The gap between the price action and the hard data is the story. The one AIS-confirmed transit count this brief tracks — IMF PortWatch's — still shows 2 vessels a day against an 85/day pre-crisis baseline, unrevised and now 11 days stale. If shipping had genuinely normalized, that is the number that would move first, and it hasn't moved at all since issue No. 35. The straits.live indices are following the price lower rather than leading it: the Escalation Forecast eased again to 53±10 from Wednesday's 58±10, a second straight decline, but the site's own methodology flags the Brent-WTI forward spread as the top input — meaning the index is substantially restating the oil move, not independently corroborating it. The dark-tanker screen fell hard, from 69.4% of scanned tankers going dark Wednesday to 44.3% today, which on its face reads as less evasive behavior — except straits.live cautions that a one-day swing of that size is as likely to reflect a change in AIS receiver coverage as an actual drop in ships going dark, and the 7-day average the site cites alongside it is

reported in a different unit (a tanker count, not a percentage), making the two numbers impossible to compare cleanly this run.

Meanwhile the on-the-ground reporting this brief can access hasn't caught up to a de-escalation story either. Iran took its case to the IMO Council overnight, per Mehr News, calling US and Israeli claims about Hormuz shipping baseless and asking the body to condemn the US naval blockade of Iranian ports — the posture of a party contesting the narrative, not standing down from it. The IRGC is still claiming activity: two tankers and a tugboat caught fire in the strait, and two US drones intercepted, both relayed only through Iranian state media with no independent confirmation. A seafarer was separately reported killed near the strait as recently as Wednesday, and a tanker was reportedly hit by projectiles off Qatar. None of this is corroborated by a second, independent outlet, but it is also not the silence a real ceasefire would produce. This brief has no independent confirmation that the Qatar/Pakistan mediation framework carried over from issue No. 35 has produced an actual agreement.

For the investor reader, the read is that the oil market is front-running a de-escalation story built mostly on rhetoric and its own price momentum, while the one slow-moving, hard-to-fake number — ship transits — still shows a strait at 2% of normal throughput. That divergence cuts both ways: if the PortWatch count catches up when it next updates, the rally has room to extend; if it doesn't, Brent's four-day round trip lower is vulnerable to reversing sharply on the next confirmed Iranian strike or claim that independent wires can stand behind. The secondary effect worth watching is gold, up another 1.48% overnight even as "risk-on" oil logic would argue the

opposite — a sign some positioning is still hedged against this unwinding.

There's a cleaner read-through to the Fed and to this reader's portfolio than to the war itself. A genuine, sustained drop in crude lowers headline CPI mechanically and takes some pressure off the energy-services line that has been sticky all year; Tuesday's CPI print (Nov. 10) will be the first chance to see whether four days of oil losses have actually fed through, though one week rarely moves a monthly index much. The more immediate market question is whether equities should be pricing the same relief the oil market is: the S&P's flat premarket print next to a softer Nasdaq-100 suggests they aren't, yet, treating this as an unambiguous risk-on signal the way Tuesday's election result was. That gap between asset classes — crude plunging, gold still bid, tech futures soft — is this brief's clearest sign that conviction in the de-escalation story is thinner than the four-session chart suggests.

Watch: the next PortWatch transit update (lags ~11 days, so likely covers early-to-mid November); any Iranian statement on a ceasefire or the Qatar framework from an outlet independent of Tehran; Friday's jobs report and Tuesday's CPI as the next hard data points for a Fed on hold until Dec. 9.

POLITICS

Beyond Tuesday's Democratic sweep (issue No. 36): the two governor races this brief flagged as newly competitive late in the cycle, Kansas and Ohio, remain uncalled as of this run — no independent source verified a projection for either, and this brief will not guess at a winner from pre-election polling averages alone. Hakeem Jeffries' path to the speakership is unaffected by anything new today; the for-

mal vote doesn't occur until the new Congress convenes Jan. 3, so this brief will not carry it as a live story again until closer to that date. With control of both chambers now decided, the practical political story shifts from the horse race to transition mechanics — committee assignments, leadership elections within each caucus, and how a lame-duck session handles any must-pass items before the new Congress is seated — none of which has produced confirmable reporting yet. The Wedgewood Polls fabrication episode (exposed Oct. 20) continues to generate no new reporting and is being treated as closed absent a fresh development.

ECONOMICS

Today's weekly jobless claims (8:30a ET) were not yet out at this brief's press time; the last confirmed reading was 194,000 for the week ended Oct. 24 (−1,000 w/w from a revised 195,000), with continuing claims at 1,701,000 for the week ended Oct. 17 (−21,000) — both still consistent with the low, stable claims regime this brief has tracked through the fall despite the payrolls volatility below. Friday's October jobs report is the next hard print, and this brief again could not verify a published consensus; for context, September's payrolls came in at just 29,000 against a 90,000 median forecast (FactSet) — a miss large enough, and a divergence from the claims data wide enough, that Friday's number carries real signal either way about which series is the better read on the labor market right now. CPI follows Nov. 10, PPI Nov. 13, and today's oil move (Lead) is the main reason Tuesday's CPI print now carries extra weight. Retail gas extended its decline to $4.1003/gal nationally, the fourth straight confirmed drop this brief has logged, moving a full day ahead of today's crude plunge reaching the pump.

BUSINESS

Two of yesterday's flagged earnings are now confirmed. Qualcomm's fiscal Q4/FY26 results (SEC 8-K): Q4 revenue $10.32B GAAP ($10.44B non-GAAP), within its own $9.7B–$10.5B guidance and above a Benzinga consensus near $10.14B; non-GAAP EPS $2.17, down 28% y/y from $3.00 but above the $2.05–$2.25 guided range and the roughly $2.02 Street estimate. QCT (chip) revenue was $9.02B, QTL (licensing) $1.30B. Full fiscal-year GAAP EPS was $12.70, inflated by a one-time $5.32-per-share tax benefit from releasing a valuation allowance; non-GAAP FY EPS was $10.54. Qualcomm guided Q1 FY27 revenue to $10.4B–$11.2B and non-GAAP EPS to $2.15–$2.35, and said it renewed long-term QTL licenses with Apple, Huawei and Transsion — the licensing renewals matter for the stock's multiple beyond this one quarter, since QTL remains Qualcomm's highest-margin segment (70%-plus EBT margin) even as QCT volumes and pricing have been the swing factor behind the y/y EPS decline. Separately, this brief can now confirm Caterpillar's actual Q3 2026 results via its own SEC 8-K — revenue $20.7B (+17% y/y), adjusted EPS $7.20 versus $4.95 a year earlier, adjusted operating margin 20.6%, and a record $78.1B backlog, up $38.2B y/y, with Power Generation sales up 30% on turbines and large engines for data-center customers — one more confirmed data point, alongside AMD's quarter (issue No. 36), that capital spending on power-hungry compute infrastructure is still showing up in hard industrial order books. Note for the record: Caterpillar's Q3 was released Oct. 29, not "today" as issue No. 36's calendar entry had it pending — a correction, not new news.

TECHNOLOGY

Nasdaq-100 futures are the one US equity gauge in the red this morning (−0.61%, against a flat S&P), and this brief reads that as the Korean chip sector's story bleeding into US tech positioning rather than an oil read: Kospi's reported 5.28% drop, if it holds up, would be the sharpest single-day move this brief has logged from Seoul in weeks, though it comes from one source only and could not be corroborated this run and should be treated with real caution until a second outlet confirms it. The contrast with Wednesday's Qualcomm and Caterpillar prints (Business) is notable — both US hardware-adjacent names posted confirmed, solid results the same week Seoul chip names are reportedly under renewed pressure, which if the Kospi figure holds would read as a region-specific unwind (positioning, FX, or a Samsung/SK Hynix-specific catalyst this brief couldn't verify) rather than a broad AI-capex scare. No frontier AI model release, funding round, or rocket launch cleared this brief's verification bar in the past 24–48 hours.

GEOPOLITICS

OPEC+'s Nov. 1 meeting, flagged unconfirmed in issue No. 36, is resolved: the seven participating producers (Saudi Arabia, Russia, Iraq, Kuwait, Kazakhstan, Algeria, Oman) held output at September's required levels for a third straight month, effective December, after pausing a run of monthly increases that had run from April through September. The group said it will keep meeting monthly to review conditions, and its next meeting is Nov. 29 — close enough to this week's oil move that a continued plunge in Brent between now and then could put renewed pressure on the group to reconsider the pause, though that is this brief's own read, not anything OPEC+ has signaled. No other standalone geopolitical development beyond the Lead and Iran & Hormuz this issue.

IRAN & HORMUZ

Beyond the Lead and Board: every Iran-side claim logged in the past 24 hours — the IRGC's tanker/tugboat-fire claim, its claimed drone intercepts, the reported projectile strike on a tanker off Qatar — traces to Iranian state media or a single wire with no independent second source, consistent with the pattern this brief has flagged since issue No. 35. The one item with a non-Iranian source is the reported death of a seafarer near the strait as recently as Wednesday (ETV Bharat), still uncorroborated elsewhere. This brief has no confirmed update on the Qatar/Pakistan mediation framework since issue No. 35's reporting, and it is worth being explicit that a wire's characterization of shipping as "recovered close to pre-war levels" (Lead) appears nowhere in this brief's own counters. The dark-tanker screen's drop to 44.3% (Lead, Board) is this issue's most significant single

data point, but straits.live's own caveats mean this brief is not treating it as confirmed de-escalation, and the war-risk premium — now 29 days stale at roughly 32x pre-crisis — has not been re-priced by the underwriters this brief would need to see move before calling the insurance market convinced.

SPORTS

Yankees	Season over. Bednar's $23.15M qualifying offer confirmed issued Nov. 2.
Knicks	Beat Chicago 135-105 Wednesday, now 4-4.
Northwestern	3-6, idle since Oct. 31; next Sat. 11/7 vs. Iowa, home.

Continuity. Dropped as unchanged: the Democratic sweep's mechanics (issue No. 36, see Politics for what's left open); AMD's and Pfizer's Q3 prints (fully covered issue No. 36). Watch for next issue: today's jobless claims and Friday's NFP; whether the PortWatch transit count updates at all; any independently-sourced Iranian statement on a ceasefire; confirmation of Kospi's −5.28% move and of Wednesday's actual Brent/WTI settle; Kansas/Ohio governor calls.

Unverified figures are marked in red: Wednesday's and today's settled Brent/WTI levels (wide cross-source spread); the 2-year Treasury yield; Europe's levels; today's jobless-claims print and October NFP consensus; Kospi's −5.28% (single-sourced); the Knicks' 135-105 final (single-sourced). Nothing was estimated or filled from memory.